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UC-Berkeley campus paper lease jeopardized

May 15, 2002 | U-Wire (USA)
Author: UC-Berkeley; Wendy Lee | Section: News | 878 Words
OpenURL Link

(*#_Company_Name_#*) BERKELEY, Calif. -- The Daily Californian's future on the University of California-Berkeley campus remains up in the air as negotiations for a lease renewal have been postponed until later this summer.

The ASUC Store Operations Board, which is negotiating the lease with the Daily Cal, heard a proposal Tuesday that could have ousted the independent student newspaper from its sixth floor offices in Eshleman Hall and given the space to student service groups. The board delayed making any final decisions until July, and asked for a study to evaluate all of the ASUC's allocations of space for various groups.

The board is comprised of five UC Berkeley students and four campus administrators, professors, and staff members.

Daily Cal Editor in Chief Rong-Gong Lin, II said he is pleased the board is still considering the lease, adding that it is important for the independent student newspaper to remain on campus to remain easily accessible to students and to actively recruit and retain new staffers.

The student-run newspaper's lease may be jeopardized by a new plan devised by ASUC President Wally Adeyemo. His plan would have replaced the Daily Cal's offices with a new center dedicated for campus service groups like Cal Corps.

Adeyemo argued space on the sixth floor is highly competitive, with 120 applicants for 16 space allocations last year.

Adeyemo said priority on the sixth floor should be given to campus service groups because they are "part of the ASUC, rather than outside it."

This is Adeyemo's last month as a Store Operations Board member. Adeyemo's seat will go to the incoming ASUC President, fellow Student Action member Jesse Gabriel.

All members of the Store Operations Board will have a vote on the lease renewal. UC Berkeley Chancellor Robert Berdahl will ultimately have the power to veto any decision made by the board.

Before making any final decisions, the board will conduct a case study of all space within Eshleman Hall to determine how much competition there is for space. If the Daily Cal's lease is not renewed, the newspaper will have six months to find another work location, the board said.

Board member Peter Buckland said the board will take measures to keep the "viability of the Daily Cal" and the forum it provides students alive.

"We will take steps to preserve those characteristics," Buckland said.

But Lin said it was "troubling" he was informed of Adeyemo's plan only hours before the Store Operations Board meeting.

"Fairness only dictates that we should have known a week before that there was a chance we could lose the ability to negotiate our rent," Lin said.

Adeyemo said it was "not his job" to inform the Daily Cal of his plan to house university affiliated service groups, though he conducted discussions with a student service organization nearly a month ago. He refused to comment as to whether the newspaper should have been notified earlier.

The Daily Cal has been independent from UC Berkeley since 1971, when the university threatened to fire three editors in response to an editorial that was written supporting students reclaiming People's Park.

The newspaper has been housed on the sixth floor of Eshleman Hall since 1995 and was previously located in the building before 1971. The rent lease will end July 31 if the Store Operations Board chooses not to renew it.

Lin said it was "important" for Daily Californian to remain on campus in order to keep its high retention and recruitment rates of student staff members. Currently, the newspaper has approximately 150 staff members.

"We would very much like to stay on campus. The campus provides us with a greater chance of stability," Lin said.

While in negotiations for a new lease, the student-run newspaper's financial state is in limbo, said the paper's general manager, Hubert Brucker. The paper currently is paying $7,428 a month for rent, while the Daily Cal is suffering financial difficulties because of a lack of advertisement revenue.

"We didn't come (to the store operations board meeting) idly. We're saying we need some help," Brucker said.

The paper is currently negotiating to lower the rent to $5,770 a month.

Tensions this past year have erupted between the Daily Cal and student government. Earlier this year, more than 100 students staged a sit-in in the Daily Cal newsroom over an editorial cartoon printed on Sept.18 depicting two men in turbans with long beards in hell, arguing it was racist and stereotypical.

During the night of the protest, Adeyemo told the demonstrators the Store Operations Board would consider their complaints about the cartoon during the Daily Cal lease negotiations. Daily Cal editors decided not to apologize for printing the cartoon.

ASUC senators also drafted a bill in October calling for a raise in the Daily Cal's rent in response to the political cartoon. That part of the motion was later killed in committee, and the senate passed a symbolic bill asking for a front-page apology and mandatory sensitivity training.

Lin said the attempt to raise the rent to protest the Daily Cal was a "political" move.

Additionally, Adeyemo wrote an editorial last week in the Daily Cal, stating the newspaper does not accurately represent student opinions.

"The Daily Cal owes students a newspaper that we can take pride in, rather than shudder at each morning," Adeyemo wrote.

Lin said the newspaper will remain an "open forum" for students to air their views.

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- **Citation (apa Style)**
  Lee, W. (2002, May 15). UC-Berkeley campus paper lease jeopardized.*Daily Californian (University of California-Berkeley) (CA)*. Available from NewsBank: Access World News – Historical and Current: https://infoweb.newsbank.com/apps/news/document-view?p=WORLDNEWS&docref=news/10F79D8C33227058.